



IRANIAN volunteers sift through rubble in Tehran on Sunday. The U.S. death toll climbed to six troops.

ANALYSIS

A battle more complex than Iraq

Toppling Iran’s government brings on new and tougher challenges

By NABIH BULOS AND
PATRICK J. McDONNELL

A shock-and-awe campaign laying down a tsunami of bombs. An enemy succumbing rapidly under overwhelming firepower. And a triumphant U.S. president trumpeting a quick and easy campaign.

In 2003, President George W. Bush strode confidently on the deck of an aircraft carrier less than five weeks

after he ordered the invasion of Iraq and declared the “end of major combat operations” under a banner proclaiming “Mission Accomplished.”

It proved anything but. The invasion became a meat grinder, leaving thousands of Americans and possibly more than a million Iraqis dead. It unleashed forces whose effects are felt in the region and beyond to this day.

More than two decades

later, another U.S. president attacked another Persian Gulf nation, promising rapid success in yet another Middle East adventure that he says will remake the region.

President Trump and his staff have vehemently rejected any comparison between “Operation Epic Fury,” launched Saturday, and “Operation Iraqi Freedom.” On Monday, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth gave a pugnacious news conference, insisting, “This is

not Iraq. This is not endless.”

Yet the assault on Iran — almost four times larger than Iraq with more than double its population — presents no lack of challenges, ones that could spread chaos far beyond Iran’s borders and become a defining feature of Trump’s presidency.

In many ways, analysts say, toppling Iran’s leadership represents a much more complex task than

No limits on length of war against Iran

Trump won’t commit to time frame despite rising concerns over the mission’s goals.

By ANA CEBALLOS
AND KEVIN RECTOR

WASHINGTON — President Trump on Monday refused to box himself in on how long U.S. military operations will last in Iran, saying the conflict in the Middle East could stretch a month or potentially “far longer” as he frames the mission as one that is necessary to eliminate a “colossal threat” to American interests.

“Whatever the time is, it’s OK. Whatever it takes,” Trump said at a White House event. “Right from the beginning, we projected four to five weeks, but we have the capability to go far longer than that. We’ll do it.”

Hours earlier, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said that the duration of the military operation remains fluid, and that Trump has “all the latitude in the world” to determine how long the war in Iran will go on.

A turnabout for the president

Goal of regime change would run counter to Trump’s campaign promises. **NATION, A6**

“Four weeks, two weeks, six weeks. It could move up. It could move back,” Hegseth told reporters at a Pentagon news conference.

The Trump administration’s shifting time frames and open-ended objectives in Iran have deepened uncertainty around an expanding conflict in the Middle East, particularly as the death toll of American troops killed in action rose to six and officials warned of more U.S. casualties, as the “hardest hits are yet to come.”

Gen. Dan Caine, the chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, said Monday that additional U.S. military forces are already moving into the region, and warned that the conflict will not be a “single, overnight operation” and that he expects “additional losses.”

[See **Trump**, A6]

State’s gas prices expected to surge

War in Mideast will be one more factor causing pain at the pump in California.

By LAURENCE
DARMIENTO

The U.S. attack on Iran is expected to have an unwelcome effect on California drivers — a jump in gas prices that could be felt at the pump in a week or two.

The outbreak of war in the Middle East, which virtually closed a key Persian Gulf shipping lane, spiked the price of a barrel of Brent crude oil by as much as \$10, with prices rising as high as \$82.37 on Monday before settling down.

The price of the international standard dictates what motorists pay for gas globally, including in California, with every dollar increase translating to 2.5 cents at the pump, said Severin Borenstein, faculty director of the Energy Insti-

tute at UC Berkeley’s Haas School of Business.

That would mean drivers could pay at least 20 cents more per gallon, though how much damage the conflict will do to wallets remains to be seen.

“The real issue though is the oil markets are just guessing right now at what is going to happen. It’s a time of extreme volatility,” Borenstein said. “We don’t know whether the war will widen or end quickly, and all of those things will drive the price of crude.”

President Trump has lauded the reduction of nationwide gas prices as a validation of his economic agenda despite worries about a weak job market and concerns of persistent inflation.

The upheaval in the Middle East could be more acutely felt in the state.

Californians already pay far more for gas than the rest of the country, with the average cost of a gallon of regular at \$4.66, up 3 cents from a

[See **Gasoline**, A3]

Cost to insure autos is going up

Rates in Golden State have skyrocketed as a result of inflation and soaring repair bills.

By LAURENCE
DARMIENTO

Jeff Phillips, a retired computer consultant who lives in Oceanside, did a double take when he saw his auto insurance bill from Garrison Property & Casualty. It was nearly \$300 more than last year.

Phillips, 60, who primarily drives a 2010 Mercedes sport utility vehicle and owns other vehicles, is now paying \$3,244 a year for coverage from the USAA subsidiary, despite a multicar and good-driver discount.

“I didn’t have any incidents that would have caused it to go up,” he said. “So I was kind of shocked that it was going up as high as it was.”

If, like Phillips, you’ve recently received your renewal for auto insurance in the mail and can’t quite believe how much it has gone up, you aren’t imagining things.

The top 10 insurers in California got the nod last year to raise premiums an average of 6% — on top of a 15.4% hike in 2024 and a 13% jump in 2023, according to S&P Capital IQ.

Add it all up and rates by insurers who write about 85% of all California auto insurance have climbed on average more than one-third from 2023 to 2025.

That means a California driver who paid the state’s average premium of \$1,087 in 2022 could be paying hundreds more today.

And that’s only for drivers who have avoided accidents and tickets that can drive premiums even higher.

Rates have surged not only in California but also nationwide, despite new

[See **Insurance**, A10]



THE MIDNIGHT HOUR in San Fernando has long been a community hub.

A time and place for unity

Midnight Hour Records a haven for immigrants

By Itzel Luna

The soft hum of Chicano soul music bled onto the darkened street as a steady stream of people made their way into a record store in San Fernando, passing a sign in the window: “ICE, BIGOTS, MAGA’ are not welcome.”

Vendor booths replaced vinyl racks, some selling miniature lowrider replicas and Chicano-inspired artwork. Attendees crowded the center of the shop, dancing to live soul music. One vendor cut and styled hair into slicked-back pompadours and high bouffants.

It was a night inspired by pachucos, the 1930s-40s Mexican American subculture of zoot suits and ducktails, caló slang and jazz, that rebelled against discrimination as a form of self-empowerment and felt especially relevant since immigration agents began mass roundups of Latinos in Los Angeles.

On its surface, the Midnight Hour is a record store, its rows lined with hundreds of vinyls collected from around the world. But to the north San Fernando Valley, it

[See **Store**, A14]



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

OSCAR RACE SHAKE-UP

Actor Awards went to Michael B. Jordan, above, and the cast of “Sinners” on Sunday, scrambling analysts’ predictions. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Marijuana and gun rights

Justices sound skeptical of Trump administration’s push to disarm “habitual” drug users. **NATION, A5**

Ellison’s plan for media merger

Paramount chair lays out his vision for combining HBO Max and Paramount+. **BUSINESS, A9**

Weather
Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 74/53. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

